The Storyteller's Silence

By Nikki Giovanni

Poems have serious business to do

Poems have to tell the truth

They need to remind people of our sacred duty

To remember the captured people whom we

called Slaves

To remember they believed in tomorrow

They believed in us

They believed in the power of a serious poem

To carry our story forward

Poems are serious business

And only serious people

Should apply

(From Serious Poems by Nikki Giovanni; Acolytes, 2007)

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INTRODUCTION

Imagine being torn from your family … forced to walk hundreds of miles until you reach the sea on the West African side of the Atlantic Ocean. You are stripped of your name, your identity, of every right a human being deserves. The European ship that you are forced to board, is filled with a multitude of black people chained together, with scarcely room to turn. Death and disease are all around and only one in six will survive this journey and the brutal, backbreaking labor that follows… The Storyteller's Silence by Nikki Giovanni

There must have been a silence.

Not a moan, not a mumbling word. But a silence.

The shock. The absolute disbelief.

The incredible stunning astonishing gaping shame.

At capture.

The incomprehensible knowledge that the sun stood still.

The stars extinguished their twinkles.

The winds and the rains fled underground.

The moon withdrew its comforting glow.

Not only the silence of different languages.

Different images.

Different words for the same objects.

The holocaustic silence of the unthinkable now made manifest.

The captured did not understand their captors.

Nor each other.

They only understood the chains. The whips.

The desecrations. The destructions. The horror.

Yet that should not. Could not.

Have been the reason for silence.

Maybe there was nothing more to say.

The long lines on the trips to the coast.

The babies crying. Then being thrown into the bush.

Or run through with a bayonet.

The mothers screaming. And fighting back.

And being murdered also.

The animals that lived the trail of the slavers.

Grew used to everything coming easy.

Grew expectant. And fat. And lazy.

Grew more evil.

In their own imaginations.

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Grew impossible to live with.

Themselves. Anyone else.

Grew crazy in the trade. Of human flesh.

And human souls.

Prayed at the river. Tithed to the church.

Searched their Bible.

And still went in the night to the captured.

And still sought relief and understanding.

And still tried to justify.

Someone had to look. To remember.

The screaming commands. The cracking whips.

The kicking boots indicating time:

To go to the big ships.

To be brave and strong.

To find a way to stay human.

Some will jump. And some will expire.

Some will kill their captors. And some will escape.

But most will find themselves. On an auction block.

Being intruded upon.

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Being violated.

Being branded and corralled.

But the spirit stayed.

And the heart remembered.

They were silent because there were no words to

express it.

The salt of the tears.

The salt of the blood.

The salt in the wounds.

All knew.

It cannot be unusual.

That the slaves left no written records.

They were denied rudimentary materials.

But they sang a song. And they preached a service.

And their story was codified. And sanctified.

And passed along.

And the second voice of the people ripped from Africa.

Whipped into the New World.

Molded on the plantations.

Came from their feet.

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The feet spoke clearly when they ran away.

And they ran away. And away. And away

so much that the South had to make America safe

for slavery by passing The Fugitive Slave Law

which would not have been needed.

If the slaves had not spoken so loudly.

Through Gabriel Prosser.

Through Denmark Vesey.

Through Nat Turner.

Through the Underground Railroad.

They spoke so loudly.

A man named John Brown.

Who wanted his sons. To be free men. Heard them.

Prayed about it. Took his sons. And led the charge.

Against Harpers Ferry.

Against the corrupt federal government.

Against his own white skin.

And started the war. That freed the slaves.

That offered to free America.

If America hadn't been too venal.

Too stupid.

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Too arrogant.

To understand what a gift had been offered.

It is not unusual that so few found a way.
It is unusual that so many did.

And out of the hearts. And hopes.

Out of the souls and salvation. The words tumbled.

The words ran to the riverside.

Shouted from the mountains.

Wove themselves into blankets.

Wrapped themselves in *Gelees**.

Whispered in the night. A freedom song.

A brave and wondrous story not of survival but of triumph.

Through thunder and fire.

Through gentle rain.

Through heavy, violent winds.

Through magnolia breezes.

The Americans who were once captured and enslaved.

The Americans who were once considered a little less than chattel.

The Americans who didn't want to come and were not happy to be here.

Now became not the voice of the slaves.

But the voice of America.

It is not nearly so unusual that the printed word is spoken.

But that the spoken word is printed.

Stamped.

Paginated.

Made available. To the world.

To tell the story. Of a person.

Of a people.

Of the undeniable will.

To prevail.

So we come to these voices.

To Zora Neale Hurston.

To Langston Hughes.

To Richard Wright.

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To Gwendolyn Brooks.

To Lorraine Hansberry.

To all of us who are ...

in the mighty words of Martin Luther King, Jr.

Free At Last! Free At Last!

Free to break our Silence.

Free to tell our story.

Free to love and laugh.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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** Gele (pronounced* gay_lay*) is a term for a woman's head wrap. This piece of clothing can be as simple as a scarf-like head-tie or bandana.*



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